

states WEST BENGAL

CRYING FOWL

The latest outbreak of bird flu in the state has dangerous ramifications for public health and India's poultry business

■ By Amarnath K. Menon and Swagata Sen

It is steadily getting worse and could easily spin out of control if it acquires a virulent form. The latest outbreak of the avian influenza sweeping West Bengal is the most serious India has ever faced—with grim portents of affecting the nation's poultry business. Already, the prices of egg and chicken have dropped in the domestic market and exporters are a worried lot with the UAE, Oman, Qatar, Nepal and Bhutan banning Indian poultry. More such bans are likely as the size of the cull, now 20 lakh birds, increases in the state along with the fear of the deadly H5N1 strain.

The spread could have been contained had the state taken timely preventive measures. As preparations for Eid were in full swing at Margram in Birbhum district, on December 15 last, Murshida Bibi, a small-time chicken farmer, noticed her flock of 33 behaving in a strange manner. The birds would go into a stupor, totter drowsily and fall. By the next morning her entire flock was dead. The village panchayat, on instructions from the local block development officer, said: "It is winter, chickens die of cold."

A month later, authorities woke up to the outbreak that has spread to 10 out of 19 districts in the state. Villagers blame the Government for not informing them about the hazards of bird flu even as many admit to roasting and eating the dead birds. Some tried to smuggle chicken, even to Bihar, to avoid losses. For the administration, it is a tough task as there are numerous backyard poultry farms rather than

large businesses. Adding to their woes is the dearth of veterinary staff which has prompted the administration to seek help from senior veterinary students. The state's Animal Resource Development Minister Anisur Rehman admits: "Lack of awareness among villagers, resistance from poultry owners and lack of veterinary staff has slowed down culling operations."

Fears about the flu getting out of hand run deep as there is a strong possibility that the source of the outbreak is Bangladesh—where the virus has spread to 26 of the 64 districts since

March last year. Migratory birds and the movement of men and material are responsible for the spread of the avian virus within a region. The state Government is yet to find ways to ensure that culled birds do not find their way to other parts of the country as cheap chicken. To appease distraught farmers, the Government plans to pay a compensation of Rs 40 for every layer bird culled and the Centre has allocated Rs 3.5 crore for the state to accelerate compensation to poultry farmers.

Exporters are feeling the pinch as the Paris-based Office International des



RISING CULL

JANUARY 2008 20,00,000 birds have been slaughtered in Birbhum, Murshidabad, Burdwan, Nadia, Bankura, Malda, Cooch Behar, South 24 Parganas, South Dinajpur, East Midnapore and Hooghly districts of West Bengal.

JULY 2007 3,36,000 birds had to be slaughtered in the eastern Imphal district of Manipur.

FEBRUARY 2006 6,57,000 birds were slaughtered in Nandurbar and Jalgaon districts of Maharashtra; Surat in Gujarat and Burhanpur district in Madhya Pradesh.



■ Districts affected by bird flu in January '08